



Health & Safety Considerations for the Management of a Multi-Faith Room

1. Ensuring a clean and well-maintained space.
 - a. Post a procedure for reporting a problem about the room / facility, including a contact email and/or telephone number of person responsible and the relevant Facilities number (St. George campus call 416-978-3000, Mississauga campus submit work order in ServiceNow: <https://uoft.service-now.com/utm>, Scarborough campus contact: <https://www.utsc.utoronto.ca/facmgt/>). **Concerns** may include:
 - i. Cleanliness
 - ii. Damage
 - iii. Temperature
 - iv. Lighting
 - v. Misuse of the room

Concerns regarding other users may be reported to the [local Equity, Diversity and Inclusion \(EDI\) lead](#) or the [Institutional Equity Office](#).

Urgent concerns

- b. In case of fire or emergency evacuation, follow procedures in the room. Room should be posted with building address, and room number. Consult your Fire Prevention Officer <https://www.fs.utoronto.ca/contact/fire-prevention-officer/> (St. George) or local campus facilities team where applicable.
 - c. In the event of incident or concern that requires attention, contact Campus Safety by calling 416.978-2222 (all three campuses). Link to Campus Safety contacts for each campus: <https://www.utoronto.ca/campus-status>
 - d. For emergencies that require an immediate response, call 9-1-1 and then notify Campus Safety.
 - e. Report incidents or injuries to the UoT contact who will complete an Accident/Incident e-Form: www.ehs.utoronto.ca/report-an-incident
2. Providing proper flooring for barefoot use (contact Caretaking to schedule cleaning St. George campus call 416-978-3000, Mississauga campus submit work order in ServiceNow: <https://uoft.service-now.com/utm>, Scarborough campus contact: <https://www.utsc.utoronto.ca/facmgt/>).
3. Open flames, incense, or smoke-producing practices are generally not permitted in most multi-faith spaces and campus buildings for health and safety reasons. **Exceptions apply to Indigenous ceremonial practices**, which [are protected and supported under University policy and provincial legislation](#). For other practices involving candles, incense or flames, please check with space administrators to determine where this may be allowed. For instance, there are certain spaces within the Multi-Faith Centre on the St. George campus which do allow for these practices to take place. : <https://map.utoronto.ca/?id=1809#!ce/80108?ct/45469?s/>.



- a. Where applicable, please refer: [Smudging and other Indigenous ceremonies involving fire or smoke at UofT](#). If Indigenous ceremonial practices take place in this space regularly, please consider [posting notices](#) to that effect.
4. Provide appropriate storage for personal items such as shoes.
5. Review security needs based on the hours of operation and access after-hours, weekends, holidays.
6. Post emergency exit procedures, safety information (e.g. “No Smoking”, “Fire Exit”, “No Flames”) in visible areas and the [EHS incident reporting procedure decal](#). Safety information should not be covered or removed by users.
7. Posting Expectations or Community Guidelines. Consider including:
 - Please reset the room and leave the space tidy for the next user. Please wipe down all mats, benches or other materials after use and return them to the appropriate cabinets or bins. Remove any materials for disposal before departing.
 - Please be mindful of noise levels when engaging in spiritual or reflective practice. Multi-faith spaces are often located near other areas used for work, study, teaching, learning, and research.
 - With the exception of drinking water, food and beverages are generally not permitted in the room. With regard to spiritual practices involving food and drink, please check with space administrators to determine where this may be allowed. For instance, there are certain spaces within the Multi-Faith Centre on the St. George campus which do allow for these practices to take place.
 - Where applicable, no candles, incense, or open flames of any kind. (Per above, this does not apply to Indigenous Ceremonial Practices and locations where such activities are permitted.)
 - Posters and notices may not be posted in the room. Instead, consider a bulletin board at the entrance to the room only, where notices related to religious, spiritual, and reflective practice may be posted. Notices will be removed every two to three weeks

Infrastructure Considerations

For departments that are considering using a space for spiritual or reflective practice here are some considerations:

Location and orientation. The room should be away from the noise and vibration (e.g. mechanical room) or high traffic areas (e.g. main entrance, lecture rooms, etc.). Privacy and accessibility are the key for the location. The room should be positioned on the following with proximity to multiple exits, preferably in different directions (e.g. the middle hallway with the option to exit to the opposite direction if one direction is blocked). Avoid the terminal ends of the hallways in the basement, where the escape routes can be limited.

Ventilation. The room should be well-ventilated and should consider the purpose of the room, the expected activities, and the number of expected users. In a situation where the room can be used for smoke, perfume/scented oils, or smoke (tobacco, sage, etc.), the ventilation should be isolated from the rest of the building and designed with 100% exhaust without recirculation. Please consult with Fire Prevention (St. George) or the local facilities team.

Ablution (washing) station. The location shall be near the prayer room with a clear path between. Ensure non-slip flooring or non-slip mats, grab bars for accessibility and thermostatically controlled water to prevent scalding. Consider a sensor-activated/hands-free faucet.

Changes to the space: When required, engage Facilities and Services to install items (markers, shelves, alters, etc.) that require drilling/cutting the building fabric. Provide information to users on who to contact to report a problem or to make changes to the space.

Soundproofing. Consider the types of noise-generating activities that may occur (e.g. music, drums, vocal prayer, etc.) in this room and consider another location where applicable. Where another location is not feasible, departments may need to consider engaging a noise consultant to provide advice on noise reduction strategies (e.g. noise-canceling materials). Note: noise can penetrate not only walls but also be transmitted from large glass panels and transferred through the ductwork and air ventilation grills.

Security. Consider the hours of use (e.g. evenings, weekends) and consult with Campus Safety as needed (e.g. “blue button” intercom, emergency assistance summoning buttons, cameras, etc.). Post emergency contact information (e.g. Campus Safety emergency phone number 416-978-2222) and resources such as [Working Alone](#), [Travel Safer](#), [Awareness Posters](#), etc.